

Caravaggio

Among the most revolutionary artists of the Baroque, Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio (1571–1610) was born in Milan, and worked in Rome, Naples, Malta and Sicily. He quickly gained success with paintings that imparted spirituality and realism, and had a formative influence on Baroque painting in general. Yet his private life was controversial, involving murder and confrontation with the Church, and his work was also contentious. In contrast with the accepted idealization of sacred individuals, he depicted holy figures as peasants with dirty feet, fingernails and clothing – an approach perceived by many as sacrilegious. His works were particularly sensational for their detailed, natural realism, and the intense, revelatory moments portrayed. Unusual compositions, featuring foreshortening and heightened *chiaroscuro* (contrast between light and dark) created emotional tension. He worked at great speed, drawing directly onto his canvases with paint on his brush handle. His models included friends, prostitutes and peasants. After his life was cut short, his followers became known as Caravaggisti or Caravagesques.



Caravaggio, *Bacchus*, c.1595